

Event Planning Report and Proposal

An inter-university hackathon for students in Ireland, adapted from a completed reference event and updated for current technology, regulation and industry practice

Item	Detail
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Companion files	IT_Summit_2027_Hackathon_Proposal.pptx (committee deck); IT_Summit_2027_Round1_Idea_Template.pptx (participant template)

About the source material

This plan is built on documents from a completed inter-college hackathon in India (the “reference event”): its website (domains, judging panel, IP policy and judging parameters), Round 1 idea-submission guidelines, ideation slide template, a planning report and a participant-journey report.

All names, logos and branding from the reference material have been removed. Where this report quotes the reference event’s approach, it says so; everything else is a proposal for IT Summit 2027.

Contents

1. Executive summary
2. Review of the reference event
3. Why these themes now: technology and regulation, 2025–26
4. Event concept and the Trust Triad
5. Challenge domains
6. Rounds, format and master timeline
7. Grand Finale run-of-show
8. Judging and awards
9. Rules, intellectual property and compliance in Ireland
10. Organisation, workstreams and volunteers
11. Budget and sponsorship framework
12. Risks and contingency plan
13. Participant journey and communications
14. After the event: follow-up and success measures
15. Decisions needed and next steps

Appendix A. Round 1 idea submission guidelines (IT Summit 2027 version)
Appendix B. Logistics and infrastructure checklist
Appendix C. Sources and verification notes

1. Executive summary

IT Summit 2027 will run an inter-university hackathon for students at higher-education institutions across Ireland. The plan keeps what worked at the reference event: an online idea round with a fixed slide structure, an equal-weighted judging rubric, a mixed start-up, industry and academic jury, detailed logistics checklists and a 24-hour on-site finale. It adapts these to Irish academic calendars and to EU and Irish regulation, and it takes on the technology issues of 2025–26: generative and agentic AI, ransomware against critical services and their suppliers, large cloud outages, and the energy cost of computing.

What this plan proposes

- **Three rounds:** an online idea submission (Round 1), a one-week online mentored build sprint for shortlisted teams (Round 2), and a 24-hour on-site Grand Finale, proposed for Saturday 13 to Sunday 14 March 2027.
- **12 challenge domains:** the reference event's 11 domains, re-scoped for Ireland and the EU, plus a new Domain 12 on optimisation, cloud and resilient systems.
- **The Trust Triad:** every project, in every domain, shows that it is secure, responsible and efficient, using a one-page Trust Card. This is the event's signature feature.
- **A declared-AI policy:** AI coding assistants are allowed, but teams must declare their use, and every member must be able to explain the code.
- **Judging that rewards quality over quantity**, with judge calibration, conflict-of-interest declarations and a clear appeals process.
- **Participant-friendly IP:** teams keep ownership of what they build.
- **A "build-on" pathway** after the event that links winning teams to mentors and to existing Irish start-up supports.

Planning size (assumption to confirm once the venue is known)

Round 1 is open to all eligible teams. Up to **50 teams** go through to Round 2, and **25 to 30 teams (about 100 to 120 students)** reach the Grand Finale.

This size fits one venue and one overnight shift pattern, and it is the basis for the staffing and catering estimates in this report.

2. Review of the reference event

2.1 What the source material covers

Source	What it covers	How this plan uses it
Event website (three screenshots)	11 challenge domains; final judging panel of start-ups, industry experts and academic leaders; IP shared between students and the host incubator; five judging parameters at 20% each "for all rounds". The live website itself could not be opened from the drafting environment, so only the screenshots were used.	Domain structure kept and re-scoped; panel mix kept; rubric kept for the online rounds and extended for the finale; IP terms changed (section 9).

Source	What it covers	How this plan uses it
Round 1 idea submission guidelines	A 5-slide idea deck (title, problem, solution, innovation, impact); PPT/PPTX/PDF only; 10 MB limit; naming convention; five 20% criteria; notes on plagiarism, visuals and a mixed jury.	Kept and extended to 6 slides with a new “Feasibility and Trust” slide (Appendix A).
Ideation slide template	Five template slides that match the guidelines.	Rebuilt as the IT Summit 2027 Round 1 template (companion file).
Hackathon planning report	Planning areas, logistics, safety and welfare, final week, event-day flow, sample 24-hour schedule, contingency plan, post-event tasks, teams and a T-60 to T+30 master timeline.	Used as the operating backbone of this plan, with dates and Irish adaptations added (sections 6 to 14).
Participant journey report	The participant’s path from discovery to post-event, a four-role team model, tools, logistics and demo contingencies.	Used to design participant communications, the handbook and the support offered at each stage (section 13).
Shared web links (event website and a share.google link)	Neither could be opened from the drafting environment (network access blocked).	Nothing in this report depends on them. Details from the full website can be added once access is allowed.

2.2 What worked and is kept

- A fixed, short Round 1 deck structure: easy for students to prepare and for judges to compare.
- A simple, transparent rubric: five criteria at 20% each.
- A mixed final jury of start-up founders, industry experts and academic leaders.
- Thorough planning checklists, including a 10 to 15% budget contingency, a waitlist for the expected 15 to 30% no-shows, judge conflict-of-interest and appeals rules, and a hard deadline with a published grace policy.
- Welfare measures: women volunteers on the night shift, a quiet room, scheduled breaks and a named conduct contact.
- A dated post-event plan (T+2, T+14, T+30) with feedback, payments, reports and follow-up for winners.
- Participant-centred guidance: a suggested four-role team, preparation for mentor sessions, and backup screenshots or video for demos.

2.3 Gaps and inconsistencies fixed in this plan

#	What we found	Why it matters	Change for IT Summit 2027
1	The slide limit is given as “5 (including title)” and as “5–7 slides” in the same guideline.	Teams cannot tell what will be penalised.	One limit, stated once: a maximum of 6 slides including the title slide.
2	The technical criterion is “Technical Potential: depth and practicality” in the guideline but “Technical Depth: quantity of architecture/code” on the website.	Quantity rewards bulk rather than quality, and AI tools make bulk easy to produce.	“Technical depth and quality”, scored on a working demo, sound architecture and code quality.
3	In the sample schedule the hard submission deadline (11:00) falls an hour before hacking ends (12:00).	Two different end times invite disputes.	One moment: code freeze and hard deadline together at H+24.

#	What we found	Why it matters	Change for IT Summit 2027
4	Round deadlines are left as “will be updated on the website”.	Students plan around coursework, and late dates cut participation.	All dates are published at launch (section 6).
5	An individual’s personal phone number is given as the contact for queries.	Privacy risk and a single point of failure.	A shared event mailbox and a helpdesk channel staffed by the team.
6	IP is shared between students and the host incubator.	This can deter strong teams, and Irish institutions have their own IP policies.	Teams keep their IP; organisers get a licence to showcase; any sponsor terms are opt-in (section 9.3).
7	Some domains refer to Indian national programmes (a national digital health mission, digital public infrastructure, MSME schemes).	Not meaningful to students, mentors or judges in Ireland.	Re-scoped to Irish and EU equivalents (section 5).
8	No rules on AI tools, security, data protection, accessibility or energy use.	These are now standard industry expectations and, in several cases, EU law.	Declared-AI policy, the Trust Triad and Trust Card, and a Trust criterion in finale judging.

3. Why these themes now: technology and regulation, 2025–26

The domains and the Trust Triad respond to developments that students will meet in their first jobs. Each point below is drawn from the public sources listed in Appendix C, checked on 4 November 2026. Regulatory dates change, so they should be re-checked before participant materials are published.

Trend	What has happened	What it means for the hackathon
AI is now regulated	The EU AI Act (Regulation (EU) 2024/1689) entered into force on 1 August 2024. Prohibited practices have applied since 2 February 2025, rules for general-purpose AI models since 2 August 2025, and transparency duties (Article 50) since 2 August 2026. Under the 2026 “Digital Omnibus” amendments, obligations for stand-alone high-risk systems move to 2 December 2027 and for high-risk AI in regulated products to 2 August 2028.	AI projects state their intended use, data sources and limits, label AI-generated content, and avoid prohibited uses. Domain 1 is framed as “Applied and Trustworthy AI”.
Ransomware against critical services and their suppliers	Ireland’s health service (HSE) was hit by Conti ransomware in May 2021; an independent post-incident review was published in December 2021. In September 2025 a ransomware attack on a third-party check-in and boarding system disrupted Dublin Airport and other European airports.	Security-by-design and supply-chain thinking feature in Domain 6, the Trust Card and the overnight mini-CTF.

Trend	What has happened	What it means for the hackathon
Cyber regulation is tightening	Ireland has not yet transposed the NIS2 Directive; the European Commission referred Ireland to the EU Court of Justice in July 2026, and the National Cyber Security Bill is still expected. The EU Cyber Resilience Act's reporting duties for actively exploited vulnerabilities and severe incidents have applied since 11 September 2026, with most other obligations from 11 December 2027.	Teams building connected products (Domains 2, 5 and 7) think about secure updates and vulnerability handling.
Cloud and software fragility	A faulty security-software update on 19 July 2024 affected about 8.5 million Windows devices (Microsoft's estimate). A major AWS outage in the us-east-1 region on 19–20 October 2025 was traced to a race condition in DynamoDB's automated DNS management.	New Domain 12 on optimisation and resilient systems; judges ask about single points of failure; the event's own platform has a tested fallback.
The energy cost of computing	Data centres used 22% of Ireland's metered electricity in 2024, up from 5% in 2015 (CSO). Later CSO figures, reported in 2026, put the 2025 share at 23%.	"Efficient" is one of the three Trust Triad pillars, and there is a Green Code award.
Accessibility is law	The European Accessibility Act has applied in Ireland since 28 June 2025 (S.I. No. 636 of 2023). It covers websites, apps, e-commerce and many other digital services.	Domain 10, plus a basic accessibility check on every user-facing project.
Digital identity and public services	Every EU member state must offer at least one certified EU Digital Identity Wallet by the end of 2026 under eIDAS 2.0.	Domain 4 includes challenges on trustworthy digital public services and verifiable credentials.
EU policy focus	Ireland holds the Presidency of the Council of the EU from July to December 2026, with competitiveness, security and values as its priorities, including AI, data and cyber resilience.	A timely hook for sponsors and public-sector partners.
Securing AI applications	The OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications (2025) lists prompt injection as the top risk.	A lightning workshop at the finale, and a Trust Card question for LLM-based projects.
Post-quantum cryptography	NIST published its first three finalised post-quantum cryptography standards (FIPS 203, 204 and 205) in August 2024.	An optional advanced challenge in Domain 6.

4. Event concept and the Trust Triad

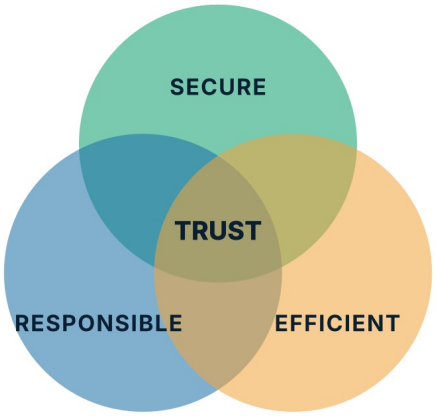
4.1 Event at a glance

Element	Proposal
Working title	IT Summit 2027 Inter-University Hackathon
Theme line	Build technology people can trust: secure, responsible, efficient
Who can enter	Undergraduate and postgraduate students aged 18 or over, enrolled at a higher-education institution in Ireland, from any discipline. Teams can mix institutions.

Element	Proposal
Team size	2 to 4 members. The reference event's four-role model is recommended: frontend/UI-UX, backend/database, research/presenter, and team manager/integration.
Format	Hybrid. Rounds 1 and 2 run online; the Grand Finale is a 24-hour on-site event.
Entry fee	Free (recommended). The event is funded by the host institution and sponsors, so cost is not a barrier to entering.
Proposed finale date	Saturday 13 to Sunday 14 March 2027: after the second-semester start, before St Patrick's Day (Wednesday 17 March) and Easter (Sunday 28 March), and clear of summer exams. To be confirmed against the host's academic calendar.
Plan B format	If overnight use of the building is not approved: a two-day format without an overnight stay (Saturday 09:00–21:00 and Sunday 08:00–17:00), with the same rounds and judging.

4.2 The Trust Triad: one baseline for every project

The Trust Triad is the event's main innovation. It is not a separate track. Every project in every domain is expected to show three baseline qualities. Together they are worth 10% of the finale score and are the basis for three special awards.



Pillar	Minimum expectation	Evidence on the Trust Card
Secure	No secrets (passwords, API keys) committed to the repository; authentication wherever personal data is handled; the three most likely threats identified and mitigated.	Top-three threats and mitigations; confirmation that secret scanning was switched on.
Responsible	Data used lawfully and within its licence; personal data kept to a minimum (GDPR); AI use disclosed and its limits stated; basic accessibility for user interfaces (WCAG 2.2 level AA where practical).	Data sources and licences; AI-use statement; accessibility checks carried out; known limitations.
Efficient	Models and infrastructure sized to the problem; no needless compute; the core flow survives one component failing.	Reason for the model and infrastructure choices; optional energy estimate (for example with the open-source CodeCarbon tool); a note on single points of failure.

Trust Card: one page, six questions

1. **Data:** What data do you use, where is it from, what licence applies, and does it include personal data?
2. **AI:** Where does the product use AI, and which AI tools did you use to build it?
3. **Risks:** What are your top three security, privacy or misuse risks, and how have you reduced them?
4. **Accessibility:** What accessibility checks have you done?
5. **Efficiency and resilience:** Why did you choose this model or infrastructure, and what happens if one part fails?
6. **Limits:** What does the prototype not do yet, and what is mocked or simulated?

5. Challenge domains

The reference event's 11 domains are kept so that the event stays broad and familiar. Each is re-scoped for Ireland and the EU, and a twelfth domain is added. The example problem statements show the intended level; the final statements will be written with mentors and sponsors and checked for data availability before Monday 11 January 2027.

#	Reference domain	IT Summit 2027 scope	Example problem statements	Open data and resources
1	Applied AI and Data Intelligence	Applied and Trustworthy AI, including AI agents	An assistant for student services that cites its sources; detecting AI-generated misinformation; a guarded AI agent for a routine business workflow.	data.gov.ie; data.europa.eu
2	Agritech and Food Safety (IoT/Software)	Agritech and Food Safety (IoT/Software)	A low-cost soil-moisture or grass-growth sensor; farm-to-fork traceability; reducing food waste in campus catering.	Met Éireann open data; Copernicus Earth observation data
3	Sustainability and Climate Action	Sustainability, Climate Action and Green Software	Home energy-use insights; a carbon-aware scheduler that moves flexible computing jobs to lower-carbon hours; a campus energy dashboard.	CSO open data (PxStat); data.gov.ie
4	Digital Public Infrastructure	Digital Public Services and Digital Identity	A plain-language, accessible guide to a public service; a verifiable student credential using open standards; an open-data explorer for local authorities.	data.gov.ie; EU Digital Identity Wallet architecture and reference framework (public)
5	Healthcare Innovation (national digital health mission, IoT/Software)	Digital Health and Wellbeing (interoperability, IoT)	A referral or appointment prototype on the HL7 FHIR standard using synthetic data; student mental-health signposting; a privacy-by-design wearable.	HL7 FHIR specification; synthetic patient data (for example Synthea). No real patient data.
6	Cybersecurity and Privacy	Cybersecurity, Privacy and AI Security	Phishing and deepfake detection for small firms; a ransomware recovery drill tool; prompt-injection defences for an LLM app; a post-quantum cryptography inventory tool.	OWASP guidance; MITRE ATT&CK; NIST post-quantum standards

#	Reference domain	IT Summit 2027 scope	Example problem statements	Open data and resources
7	Smart Mobility and Logistics (IoT/Software)	Smart Mobility and Logistics (IoT/Software)	Predicting public-transport reliability; last-mile delivery route optimisation; a cycling-safety map.	National Transport Authority GTFS and GTFS-Realtime feeds (free API key); OpenStreetMap
8	EdTech and Skills Empowerment	EdTech and Skills	A study coach that cites course material and respects academic integrity; mapping skills gaps from job adverts; accessible lecture captioning.	Open course material; data.gov.ie
9	MSME Digitization and Commerce	SME Digitalisation and Commerce	An accessibility checker for small online shops (European Accessibility Act); invoice and receipt automation; a cyber-hygiene assistant for micro-businesses.	WCAG 2.2; CSO business statistics
10	Accessibility and Inclusive Tech	Accessibility and Inclusive Tech	Tools that support Irish Sign Language users; screen-reader-friendly campus navigation; simplifying complex forms.	WCAG 2.2; National Disability Authority guidance on the European Accessibility Act
11	Open Domain (Student Innovation)	Open Domain (Student Innovation)	Any idea that does not fit the other domains. The Trust Triad still applies.	Any lawful open data
12 (new)	Not in reference event	Optimisation, Cloud and Resilient Systems	A cloud cost-and-carbon optimiser (FinOps); a chaos-testing tool for a small microservice; a campus timetable or room-booking optimiser; an incident runbook assistant.	Open-source tools such as Kubernetes, Google OR-Tools, and Chaos Mesh or LitmusChaos

- **Hardware:** Domains 2, 5 and 7 allow IoT work. The reference event's hardware practice is kept: a published component list by Friday 19 February 2027, a kit issue-and-return log, and spare boards in the contingency kit. Teams may bring their own kits.
- **Domain prizes:** a domain prize is awarded only if at least three finalist teams compete in that domain. Otherwise the domain is merged into the general ranking, which stops a domain being won by default.

6. Rounds, format and master timeline

6.1 Round 1: idea submission (online)

- Opens **Monday 18 January 2027** and closes **Friday 12 February 2027 at 17:00 (Irish time)**. No deadline falls on the St Brigid's Day bank holiday (Monday 1 February 2027).
- Deliverable: an idea deck of **no more than 6 slides including the title slide**, in PPTX or PDF, up to 10 MB, named TeamName_Institution_TeamID_Round1 (the reference event's convention). Full guidelines are in Appendix A, and a template is supplied.
- Judging: the reference event's five criteria at 20% each. Two screening judges score each deck; a third scores it if the first two differ by more than 20 points.
- Outcome: up to 50 teams shortlisted, announced **Friday 19 February 2027**.

6.2 Round 2: mentored build sprint (online) – new

- Runs **Monday 22 February to Monday 1 March 2027 (12:00)**.
- Each shortlisted team has one 20-minute online mentor session.
- Deliverables: a 3-minute video (problem, architecture and an early proof of concept or clickable prototype), an architecture diagram, a draft Trust Card and the repository link.
- Why it is added: it tests feasibility before anyone travels, gives teams feedback early, and screens out “idea-only” teams, which reduces no-shows at the finale.
- Outcome: 25 to 30 finalist teams plus a waitlist of 5, announced **Friday 5 March 2027**. Teams confirm within 48 hours or their place passes to the waitlist.

6.3 Grand Finale: 24 hours on site

- **Saturday 13 to Sunday 14 March 2027** (proposed).
- **Declared baseline:** teams continue from their Round 2 repository. At kick-off each team tags its repository (“finale-start”), so judges can see what was built on site. Any other pre-existing code, templates or libraries must be declared, in line with the reference event’s originality policy.
- Mentor rounds and checkpoints at fixed times, two short workshops, an optional overnight mini-CTF, and a single hard deadline at H+24.

6.4 Master timeline

The reference event’s T-60 to T+30 plan is mapped onto real dates. T0 is Saturday 13 March 2027. December is kept light because of semester 1 exams and the holidays.

Date	T	Milestone	Lead workstream
By Fri 27 Nov 2026		Concept approved by the committee and host institution; core team formed; venue on hold; draft budget; sponsor deck ready.	Convener and Volunteer Coordinator
Mon 30 Nov – Fri 11 Dec 2026		Sponsor outreach; judges and mentors invited; rules, code of conduct, privacy notice and IP terms drafted; registration platform chosen and tested.	Sponsorship; Mentors and judging; Data protection
Mid Dec 2026 – early Jan 2027		Pause for exams and holidays. Only sponsor follow-ups continue.	Sponsorship
Mon 11 Jan 2027	T-61	Problem statements, datasets and website final; legal review of rules and IP terms complete.	Challenges and content
Mon 18 Jan 2027	T-54	Launch: registration and Round 1 open; outreach to all institutions through campus ambassadors.	Marketing; Registration
Wed 27 Jan 2027	T-45	Online information session and team-formation mixer.	Registration
Fri 12 Feb 2027	T-29	Round 1 closes at 17:00.	Registration
Fri 19 Feb 2027	T-22	Shortlist announced; venue, catering and sponsors confirmed; hardware list published.	Mentors and judging; Hospitality
Mon 22 Feb – Mon 1 Mar 2027	T-19 to T-12	Round 2 build sprint and mentor sessions.	Mentors and judging
Fri 5 Mar 2027	T-8	Finalists announced; 48-hour confirmation; waitlist active; volunteer training session 1.	Registration; Safety and volunteers

Date	T	Milestone	Lead workstream
Mon 8 – Fri 12 Mar 2027	T-5 to T-1	Final week: reconfirm vendors, guests, judges and mentors; rehearse registration, A/V and the submission platform; Wi-Fi load test; volunteer briefing; venue set-up.	All
Sat 13 – Sun 14 Mar 2027	T0	Grand Finale.	All
By Tue 16 Mar 2027	T+3	Feedback forms; thank-you messages; photos and videos sorted; venue handover.	Registration; Marketing
By Fri 26 Mar 2027	T+13	Prizes paid; certificates issued; results and highlights published, all before Easter.	Sponsorship and finance
Mon 12 Apr 2027	T+30	Budget reconciled; final event report; sponsor impact report; lessons-learned review.	Convener and Volunteer Coordinator
April – May 2027		Six-week build-on sprint for winning and selected teams.	Mentors and judging

7. Grand Finale run-of-show

This schedule is adapted from the reference event's sample 24-hour schedule. Hacking starts earlier than in the reference schedule because teams arrive with a shortlisted idea and a Round 2 prototype. The reference event's ceremonial items (lamp-lighting or invocation) are replaced by a short opening suited to an Irish university setting.

Time	Saturday 13 March 2027
07:30	Check-in: ID check, lanyards (including a "no photos" lanyard option), Wi-Fi and platform access, hardware log
09:00	Opening: welcome, theme and the Trust Triad, sponsors, rules, code of conduct and judging criteria
10:00	Orientation: problem-statement Q&A, introduction of mentors, helpdesk and channels; teams tag their repositories "finale-start"
11:00	Hacking starts (H+0)
13:00	Lunch
14:00	Lightning workshop 1 (30 minutes): securing LLM apps, based on the OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications
15:00	Mentor round 1 and checkpoint 1: scope locked
18:00	Lightning workshop 2 (30 minutes): accessible interfaces with WCAG 2.2
19:00	Dinner
21:00	Mentor round 2 and checkpoint 2: core flow working; backup demo video recorded
23:30	Late-night snacks
00:00	Mini-CTF (90 minutes, optional, beginner-friendly, hosted on the open-source CTFd platform)

Time	Sunday 14 March 2027
01:30 – 06:30	Overnight build. Helpdesk, first aid and security on duty; quiet room and rest area open
07:00	Breakfast
08:00	Mentor round 3: demo rehearsal
10:00	Submission portal opens
11:00	Code freeze and hard deadline (H+24): repository, deck, Trust Card and backup demo video
11:00 – 12:00	Submission checks (commit history, AI-use statement, completeness); judge briefing and calibration
12:00	Lunch
12:45 – 14:45	Panel judging: three panels in parallel, about 10 teams each; 7-minute pitch and demo plus 5 minutes of Q&A
15:00	Project expo and People's Choice voting; panels confirm their top two teams
15:30 – 16:30	Final round: the top 6 teams present to the final panel
16:30	Final deliberation (expo continues)
17:00	Closing: awards, certificates, thanks to sponsors, mentors and volunteers, vote of thanks, group photo
18:00	Event closes; check-out and venue handover

8. Judging and awards

8.1 Panels

- **Screening (Rounds 1 and 2):** academics, industry engineers and alumni, with two judges per submission.
- **Finale panels:** three panels of three judges (an industry engineer, an academic and a start-up founder or investor). Across the three panels there is at least one security or responsible-AI specialist. Reserve judges are confirmed in advance, as at the reference event.
- **Final panel:** five judges, keeping the reference event's mix of start-ups, industry experts and academic leaders, plus a security or AI-governance practitioner and an accessibility or UX specialist.

8.2 Rubric

Criterion	Rounds 1 and 2 (reference event, kept)	Finale (proposed)	What judges look for
Innovation and creativity	20%	20%	How original the idea is compared with existing solutions
Feasibility	20%	15%	Real-world applicability, data availability, cost and adoption barriers

Criterion	Rounds 1 and 2 (reference event, kept)	Finale (proposed)	What judges look for
Technical depth and quality	20%	25%	A working demo, sound architecture, code quality, and what was built on site. Replaces “quantity of architecture/code”.
Impact	20%	15%	Societal or industrial value, target users and ability to scale
Presentation and teamwork	20%	15%	Clarity, Q&A, and whether every member can explain their part
Trust Triad (secure, responsible, efficient)	Covered on slide 6 of the idea deck	10%	Evidence on the Trust Card
Total	100%	100%	

8.3 Scoring practice

- **Anchored scale:** each criterion is scored 1 to 5 against written descriptors and then weighted. This is quicker and more consistent than marking out of 100.
- **Calibration:** before scoring starts, all judges score one sample pitch video together and talk through their differences. This makes harsh and lenient judges more consistent.
- **Fair progression:** the top two teams from each parallel panel go through to the final round. Teams are never ranked across panels whose judges differ.
- **Conflict of interest:** judges declare any links to teams or institutions and do not score those teams (a reference event rule).
- **Tie-breakers:** the higher technical depth and quality score wins, then the higher impact score, then a vote of the final panel.
- **Appeals:** a written appeal can be made within 30 minutes of results. A named appeals panel (the convener and one judge with no conflict) decides within 60 minutes, and its decision is final.

8.4 Awards

Award	Basis
Overall winner, first runner-up and second runner-up	Final panel
Domain awards	Only for domains with at least three finalist teams
Best Trustworthy AI	Strongest responsible-AI evidence (Trust Card and Q&A)
Security-by-Design award	Best threat analysis and security implementation
Green Code award	Best efficiency and resilience choices, with evidence
Inclusive Design award	Best accessibility and inclusive design
People’s Choice	Votes from participants and visitors at the expo
Mini-CTF champions	Top scorers in the overnight capture-the-flag

Prize values are agreed with sponsors and published before Round 1 closes.

9. Rules, intellectual property and compliance in Ireland

9.1 Core participant rules

- Participants are aged 18 or over and enrolled at a higher-education institution in Ireland. Eligibility is checked with an institutional email address or student ID.
- Teams have 2 to 4 members, and each person can join only one team. Team changes are allowed up to the Round 2 deadline with organiser approval.
- Originality: the work must be the team's own. Pre-existing code, templates and libraries are allowed only if declared, and open-source licences must be respected.
- Data: open, synthetic or self-collected data only, with consent. No real patient data, and no personal data collected without consent.
- One hard deadline with a published grace policy that applies to everyone. If an outage happens, the deadline is extended by the length of the outage and the change is announced to all teams (a reference event practice).
- Everyone follows the code of conduct, which is published at registration and repeated at the opening.

9.2 Declared-AI policy (new)

- **Allowed:** AI coding assistants, chat assistants, and AI models and APIs, within their terms of service.
- **Required:** an "AI Use Statement" in the README listing the tools used and what they were used for. Any AI features in the product are disclosed to its users.
- **Checked:** judges may ask any team member to explain any part of the code. If the team cannot explain its core functionality, its technical depth score is lowered.
- **Not allowed:** passing off another team's work or an existing project as new work, or using pre-built code without declaring it. Either can lead to disqualification by the appeals panel.

9.3 Intellectual property

The reference event used IP shared between students and its host incubator, which then offered to incubate and scale projects through its ecosystem. For an inter-university event in Ireland this plan proposes:

- **Teams keep ownership** of everything they create.
- By entering, teams give the organisers a **non-exclusive licence** to show project names, descriptions, images and demo videos for event promotion and reporting.
- **Sponsor challenges** with different IP terms must publish those terms before registration opens, and entering them is optional.
- **Incubation stays available but is never a condition of entry:** interested teams are introduced to campus incubators and national programmes after the event (section 14).
- The final wording should be reviewed by the host institution's legal or technology-transfer office, because institutional IP policies can apply to students.

9.4 Organiser compliance checklist

Area	Action	Owner
Data protection (GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018)	Privacy notice at registration; collect only what is needed; access limited to named organisers using multi-factor authentication; delete participant data 12 months after the event unless people opt in to an alumni list; data-protection screening with the host institution's Data Protection Officer.	Data protection and accessibility lead
Photos and video	Consent captured at registration; a "no photos" lanyard colour; photographer and social-media volunteers briefed.	Marketing and PR
Code of conduct and safeguarding	Published anti-harassment code; named contacts; a reporting form; women volunteers on the night shift (a reference event practice); 18+ only. If under-18s are ever admitted: parental consent, child-safeguarding obligations, and Garda vetting of volunteers through the host institution.	Safety and volunteers
Accessibility	Step-free venue and accessible toilets; captions for main-stage sessions where possible; a quiet room (a reference event practice); access and dietary needs asked at registration.	Data protection and accessibility lead
Food	The caterer provides information on the 14 regulated allergens (EU Regulation 1169/2011); vegetarian, vegan, halal and gluten-free options; water stations.	Hospitality and logistics
Insurance and venue	Confirm the host institution's public-liability cover; get written approval for overnight use of the building; security staff contract; fire-safety briefing.	Convener
Alcohol	Alcohol-free event.	Convener
Sponsor credentials	Cloud credits and API keys issued per team, with spending caps and expiry dates, and revoked after the event.	Technical and platforms
Weather and travel	Monitor Met Éireann weather warnings and transport notices. The convener decides 24 hours ahead whether to switch to an online finale if a Status Red warning is issued.	Convener

10. Organisation, workstreams and volunteers

The reference event's team structure is kept and three workstreams are added. The faculty or host convener holds approvals and final decisions. The Volunteer Coordinator runs the workstreams day to day, recruits and trains volunteers, chairs a weekly stand-up (daily in the final week) and escalates issues to the convener.

Workstream	Responsible for	Origin
Convener and core	Approvals, decisions, escalation, budget authority	Reference event
Volunteer Coordinator (Mohit Behl)	Coordinating all workstreams, volunteer recruitment and training, shift rota, stand-ups, run-of-show ownership	Role for IT Summit 2027
Registration and participants	Platform, screening, communications, check-in, kits, participant handbook	Reference event

Workstream	Responsible for	Origin
Technical and platforms	Internet, power, platforms, helpdesk, submissions, A/V, sponsor credentials	Reference event
Mentors and judging	Selection, rubric, calibration, schedule, scoring, Round 2 mentor sessions	Reference event
Sponsorship and finance	Sponsors, budget, prizes, payments, sponsor report	Reference event
Hospitality and logistics	Food, venue, guests, travel and accommodation information	Reference event
Marketing and PR	Branding, outreach to every institution, social media, photography	Reference event
Safety and volunteers	Security, first aid, conduct, night shifts	Reference event
Challenges and content	Problem statements, datasets, workshops, mini-CTF	New
Data protection and accessibility	Privacy notice, data-protection screening, consent, accessibility	New
Event operations room	Live tracker for check-in, mentor queue, incidents and timings; incident log; on-duty incident lead for each shift	New

10.1 Finale volunteer rota (planning estimate)

Role	Per day shift	Overnight shift
Registration desk	4	0
Helpdesk and technical	3	2
Mentor queue and runners	2	1
Hospitality	3	1
Safety and first aid (trained)	2	2
Photography and social media	1	0
Operations room	1	1
Total on duty	16	7

Allowing for rest breaks and three shifts, recruit about **35 volunteers**. Each shift has a named lead, and at least two women volunteers are on the overnight shift. Training: session 1 at T-8 (roles, code of conduct, safeguarding, data protection) and a walk-through at the venue at T-1.

11. Budget and sponsorship framework

No costs are estimated here: amounts depend on the venue, the host institution’s in-kind support and supplier quotes. The structure below follows the reference event’s practice of an itemised budget, an expense tracker and a 10 to 15% contingency.

Budget line	Main cost driver	How to estimate
Venue	Rooms for opening, building, mentoring, judging, rest and dining	Often provided in kind by the host; confirm any charges for out-of-hours use and security

Budget line	Main cost driver	How to estimate
Catering	Headcount × meals	About 185 people at peak (up to 120 finalists, about 35 volunteers, about 20 mentors and judges, about 10 guests) × 6 meal and snack points, from caterer quotes
Internet and power	Backup line, extension boards, charging points, UPS	Host IT quote; hire costs
A/V and streaming	Projectors, microphones, sound, cameras, live stream	Host A/V team or hire quote
Print and merchandise	ID lanyards, signage, certificates, trophies, kits	Unit price × quantity
Prizes	Cash and in-kind prizes	Agreed with sponsors
Hardware	IoT kits and spares for Domains 2, 5 and 7	Component list × expected IoT teams, plus 20% spares
Security and first aid	Overnight security, first-aid cover	Contractor or host quote
Travel bursaries (new, optional)	Support for finalists travelling from other regions	Fixed fund, allocated on application
Contingency	Unplanned costs	10 to 15% of the total (reference event practice)

11.1 Sponsorship tiers

Tier	Typical contribution	Benefits
Title partner	The largest cash contribution	Named in the event title line; keynote slot; own sponsor challenge; a seat on the final panel; recruitment booth; logo on all materials; opt-in CV book (with participant consent under GDPR)
Gold	Cash or prize funding	Lightning workshop slot; booth; mentor team; logo on website and stage slides
Silver	Smaller cash or prize funding	Logo; shared booth space; mentors
Community and in-kind	Cloud credits, APIs, hardware, food, merchandise	Logo and thanks on stage

As at the reference event, signed agreements list exactly what each sponsor provides (cash, credits, APIs, prizes, merchandise, mentors, stands) and are signed before Friday 19 February 2027. Sponsor challenges must respect the Trust Triad and the IP terms in section 9.3.

12. Risks and contingency plan

The reference event's contingency plan is kept in full (marked "Ref"). New risks (marked "New") reflect the issues described in section 3.

Risk	Prevention	Fallback	Source
Internet fails	Backup line; separate event Wi-Fi network; load test in the final week	Hotspots; extend the deadline by the length of the outage and announce it	Ref
Power fails	Check the UPS and generator	Spare extension boards and charging points	Ref
Submission platform goes down	Test it; open submissions 60 minutes early	Backup by email or shared drive, checked by timestamp	Ref
A judge is absent	Confirm reserve judges	Reserve judges or mentors step in	Ref
Dispute or complaint	Clear rules; a briefing at the opening	Named appeals panel with a time limit	Ref
Medical or safety incident	First-aid cover; emergency numbers displayed	First aid; emergency list; incident log	Ref
Late submissions	Countdown announcements	The published grace policy applies to everyone	Ref
Cloud or AI API outage, or rate limits, during hacking	Teams cache and mock key services and record a backup demo video by checkpoint 2	Judges accept the recorded demo and a code walk-through, with no penalty for a provider outage	New
Phishing or scam messages aimed at participants	Publish the official channels; state that organisers never ask for passwords or payments	Warning posted by the operations room; reports go to the helpdesk	New
API keys or secrets leaked	Per-team keys with spending caps; secret scanning recommended	Revoke and reissue the keys	New
Personal-data incident	Minimal data; access controls; multi-factor authentication	Follow the host institution’s breach procedure; inform its Data Protection Officer immediately (GDPR sets a 72-hour deadline for notifying the Data Protection Commission where required)	New
Disputes over AI use or undeclared prior work	Declared-AI policy; “finale-start” repository tag; commit history check	Appeals panel review	New
Severe weather or transport disruption	Monitor Met Éireann warnings; publish travel information	Switch to an online finale or adjust deadlines	New
High no-show rate (the reference event expects 15 to 30%)	Round 2 filters for commitment; 48-hour confirmation	Waitlist of 5 teams	Ref + New
Low registrations from some institutions	Campus ambassadors and student-society partners at each institution	Targeted outreach in the final two weeks of Round 1	New

13. Participant journey and communications

This section uses the reference event's participant-journey report to decide what support the organisers give at each stage.

Stage	What participants do	What IT Summit 2027 provides
Discover and register	Check eligibility, theme, rules and dates; form a team; register	Website with all dates; FAQ; campus ambassadors; online information session (27 January)
Form a team	Cover the four roles; agree tools and how they will work	Team-formation mixer and matching channel; four-role guidance
Round 1	Research the problem; write the 6-slide idea deck	Template and guidelines (Appendix A); office hours on the helpdesk
Shortlist and Round 2	Mentor call; 3-minute video; draft Trust Card	Mentor booking; written feedback
Before the finale	Plan travel; pack; set up accounts and repository	Participant handbook: venue, schedule, packing list, Wi-Fi, hardware list, code of conduct
Finale	Build, attend mentor rounds and checkpoints, rest	Helpdesk; mentor queue; workshops; quiet room and rest area; meals
Judging	Pitch, demo, Q&A	Clear timings; backup demo policy; equipment check
After the event	Feedback; certificates; keep building	Certificates; results; build-on sprint; alumni community

13.1 Channels

- **Website:** the single source of truth for rules, dates and FAQs.
- **Shared event mailbox:** for official notices and private questions. It is role-based, not a personal address.
- **Community server** (for example Discord): #announcements, #helpdesk, #mentor-queue and #team-formation. The reference event used Discord, Slack or WhatsApp.
- **Packing list** (from the reference event): laptop, charger, student ID, phone, permitted peripherals, required software and accounts, backup files. Add a travel adapter for visiting international students; Ireland uses Type G sockets.

14. After the event: follow-up and success measures

14.1 Follow-up

When	Tasks
T0 to T+3 (by Tue 16 Mar 2027)	Feedback forms for participants, mentors, judges and volunteers; attendance records; venue handover and logistics settlement; photos and videos sorted; thank-you messages
T+3 to T+14 (by Fri 26 Mar 2027)	Prize and supplier payments tracked; certificates and follow-up email; results, highlights and press release; winners' showcase

When	Tasks
T+15 to T+30 (by Mon 12 Apr 2027)	Budget reconciliation and expense report; final event report; sponsor report on reach and impact; lessons-learned review; plans for the next edition
April – May 2027 (new)	Six-week build-on sprint: fortnightly mentor check-ins for winning and selected teams; a showcase slot at IT Summit 2027 if the timing allows

Pathways after the event: interested teams are introduced to campus incubators and enterprise offices, and to Enterprise Ireland's New Frontiers entrepreneur development programme, which runs through Technological Universities and institutes across the country (intake dates vary by location). Teams are encouraged to publish their code under an open-source licence and to keep their repositories maintained.

14.2 Success measures

The reference event tracked attendance against registrations, submissions, satisfaction scores, prototypes continued, sponsor satisfaction, budget variance and incident count. These are kept, and diversity and reach measures are added. Targets are proposals for a first edition.

Measure	Proposed target	How it is measured
Finalist attendance compared with confirmations	90% or more	Check-in records
Finalist teams that demo a working prototype	80% or more	Judging records
Institutions represented in Round 1	8 or more	Registration data
Women and non-binary participants	30% or more	Optional, anonymous diversity question
Participant satisfaction	Average of 4 out of 5 or higher	Post-event survey
Serious safety or data incidents	Zero	Incident log
Budget variance	Within ±10%	Final reconciliation
Projects still active after 30 days	25% or more	Repository activity
Sponsor satisfaction and intention to return	4 out of 5 or higher	Sponsor survey
Trust Cards completed by finalists	100%	Submission checks

15. Decisions needed and next steps

The following decisions are requested from the organising committee by **Friday 27 November 2026**:

1. Approve the concept, the three-round format and the proposed finale dates (Saturday 13 to Sunday 14 March 2027), or choose the Plan B format.
2. Confirm the host venue and whether overnight use of the building is permitted.
3. Approve the IP terms and the declared-AI policy, subject to legal or technology-transfer review.
4. Appoint the faculty convener and the leads of the 10 workstreams.
5. Approve a budget envelope and the sponsorship tiers, and authorise sponsor outreach.

6. Approve the 12 domains and name a domain owner for each to vet problem statements by Monday 11 January 2027.

Prepared by

Mohit Behl, Volunteer Coordinator, IT Summit 2027

Contact: the shared event mailbox, to be set up once the committee approves this plan

Appendix A. Round 1 idea submission guidelines (IT Summit 2027 version)

This appendix adapts the reference event's guidelines. Changes are marked "new".

Overview

In Round 1, teams submit a short presentation that explains the problem, the proposed solution, what makes it unique, its likely impact, and (new) how feasible and trustworthy it is. **Maximum: 6 slides, including the title slide.**

1. Format

- File type: PPTX or PDF only. Use the IT Summit 2027 template if possible.
- Slide limit: 6 slides including the title slide. Extra slides are not judged.
- Design: clean, simple visuals with bullet points rather than paragraphs. Use diagrams and charts where they help.

2. Mandatory slide structure

Slide	Content
1. Title	Team name; member names, year, programme and institution; project or idea name; domain number (1–12); optional logo or concept image. Do not put phone numbers on slides: contact details are collected securely in the registration form (new).
2. Problem statement	A clear definition of the problem; why it matters; supporting statistics or facts, with sources.
3. Proposed solution	The idea in simple terms; how it solves the problem; key features; basic technology stack or approach.
4. Innovation and uniqueness	How it differs from existing solutions; technical, creative or business innovations.
5. Impact and target users	Who benefits; expected social, technical or commercial outcomes.
6. Feasibility and trust (new)	Data sources and licences; AI use (in the product and in building it); top risks for security, privacy or misuse and how you will reduce them; what you will build in Round 2.

3. File naming

TeamName_Institution_TeamID_Round1 (for example, ByteForge_InstitutionName_T042_Round1).

4. Submission

- Deadline: Friday 12 February 2027 at 17:00 (Irish time). Dates for all rounds are on the event website from launch.
- Method: upload through the registration platform. File size limit: 10 MB.

5. Evaluation criteria (each 20%)

- Innovation and creativity: how original the idea is.
- Feasibility: real-world applicability.
- Presentation quality: clarity and structure.
- Technical potential: depth and practicality.
- Impact: societal or industrial value.

6. Important notes

- Keep to the slide limit. Slides beyond the sixth are not judged.
- No plagiarism: credit all sources, images and third-party assets.
- AI tools may be used to prepare the deck. Say so on slide 6 (new).
- Write for a mixed jury of industry and academic experts.
- Queries: the event mailbox or the #helpdesk channel.

Appendix B. Logistics and infrastructure checklist

Adapted from the reference event's planning report, with notes for Ireland.

Area	Must-do (reference event)	Irish and IT Summit 2027 additions
Venue	Halls for the opening, building, mentoring, judging, rest, dining and registration; seating plan, signage and decoration; washrooms open 24 hours; sleeping zone	Written approval for overnight use; step-free access; a quiet room; a prayer or reflection room if available
Internet and power	Bandwidth for every device plus a backup line; extension boards, charging points, generator	A separate event Wi-Fi network for guests without eduroam access; Type G adapters at the helpdesk
Equipment	Projectors, microphones, sound, cameras, live stream; hardware kits with an issue-and-return log; sponsor credits and API keys shared early	Per-team keys with spending caps and expiry
Platforms	Submission platform tested; channels for announcements, questions and mentor requests	Multi-factor authentication on organiser accounts; least-privilege access to participant data
Food and guests	Caterer, meals, late-night snacks, drinking water, dietary needs; guest hospitality; transport and accommodation for guests from elsewhere	Allergen information; late-night transport information; optional travel bursaries
Print and merchandise	ID cards, kits, certificates, trophies, prizes, score sheets, signage	"No photos" lanyard colour; digital certificates to cut printing
Safety	First aid, nearby hospital, emergency numbers; marked exits, extinguishers, ID-based entry log, overnight security, lost and found	Weather-warning check 24 hours ahead; incident log in the operations room
Final week	Reconfirm everyone; rehearse registration, A/V, Wi-Fi and the submission platform; brief volunteers; prepare the run-of-show, contact sheet and contingency kit	Calibration video for judges ready; phishing warning sent to all finalists

Appendix C. Sources and verification notes

Facts in section 3 and elsewhere were checked against these public sources on 4 November 2026. Several are secondary reports; regulatory dates in particular should be re-checked against official texts before participant materials are published.

Proposed dates were checked against the 2027 calendar: St Brigid's Day bank holiday is Monday 1 February, St Patrick's Day is Wednesday 17 March, and Easter Sunday is 28 March 2027. Institution-specific term, reading-week and exam dates must be confirmed with the host.

Reference event materials (anonymised)

- Event website screenshots: domains 1–11, final judging panel, IP policy, judging parameters.
- Round 1 idea submission guidelines and ideation slide template.
- Hackathon planning report and participant journey report.
- The reference event's live website and a shared link (share.google) could not be accessed from the drafting environment; only the screenshots provided were used.

Regulation and policy

- EU AI Act high-risk delay (Digital Omnibus): https://www.jdsupra.com/legalnews/eu-legislators-agree-to-delay-for-high-5617765/
- AI Act Digital Omnibus agreement: https://www.winstontaylor.com/insights/ai-act-rules-on-high-risk-ai-delayed-as-ai-digital-omnibus-agreed
- Ireland referred to CJEU over NIS2: https://www.lawsociety.ie/gazette/top-stories/2026/july/ireland-referred-to-cjeu-over-cyber-bill/
- Government pledge on delayed cyber bill: https://www.lawsociety.ie/gazette/top-stories/2026/october/government-pledge-on-delayed-cyber-bill/
- Cyber Resilience Act reporting (European Commission): https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/cra-reporting
- European Accessibility Act in Ireland (CCPC): https://www.ccpc.ie/business/european-accessibility-act-becomes-law-in-ireland-on-28-june-2025/
- European Accessibility Act (National Disability Authority): https://nda.ie/eaa
- EU Digital Identity Wallet: https://www.lexisnexis.com/en-gb/legal/news/the-eu-digital-identity-wallet-what-companies-need-to-know
- Ireland's EU Council Presidency priorities: https://epthinktank.eu/2026/07/01/what-are-irelands-priorities-for-its-upcoming-presidency-of-the-council-of-the-eu/

Incidents and industry data

- HSE Conti cyber attack, independent review: https://www.hse.ie/eng/services/publications/conti-cyber-attack-on-the-hse-full-report.pdf
- Airport check-in cyber attack, September 2025: https://www.irishtimes.com/world/europe/2025/09/20/cyberattack-disrupts-operations-at-heathrow-and-other-european-airports
- Airport attack confirmed as ransomware: https://therecord.media/europe-airports-delays-ransomware-attack-checkin-systems
- AWS us-east-1 outage post-mortem summary: https://www.infoq.com/news/2025/11/aws-dynamodb-outage-postmortem
- July 2024 faulty update, 8.5 million devices (Microsoft): https://blogs.microsoft.com/blog/2024/07/20/helping-our-customers-through-the-crowdstrike-outage/
- Data centre electricity 2024 (CSO): https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-dcmec/datacentresmeteredelectricityconsumption2024/keyfindings/
- Data centre electricity 2025 (report on CSO data): https://www.irishexaminer.com/business/companies/arid-41875214.html
- NIST post-quantum standards: https://www.nist.gov/news-events/news/2024/08/nist-releases-first-3-finalized-post-quantum-encryption-standards
- OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications: https://genai.owasp.org/llm-top-10/
- WCAG 2.2: https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/

Data, tools and programmes referenced

- NTA developer portal (GTFS-Realtime): https://developer.nationaltransport.ie/
- Irish open data portal: https://data.gov.ie/
- EU open data portal: https://data.europa.eu/
- Enterprise Ireland New Frontiers: https://www.enterprise-ireland.com/en/news/new-frontiers-networking-event-brings-together-158-founders
- CodeCarbon (energy estimation): https://codecarbon.io/
- CTFd (open-source CTF platform): https://ctfd.io/